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REPORT

ON THE

CENSUS OF THE PANJAB

TAKEN ON THE

17TH OF FEBRUARY 1881.

BY

DENZIL CHARLES JELF IBBETSON,

OF HER MAJESTY'S BENGAL CIVIL SERVICE.

VOLUME I.

TEXT; AND APPENDICES C AND D.

(SUPPLEMENTARY TABLES AND INSTRUCTIONS.)

FINAL TABLES IN VOLUMES II AND III.



CALCUTTA:
PRINTED BY THE SUPERINTENDENT OF GOVERNMENT PRINTING, INDIA.
1883.

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PREFACE.

IN writing the accompanying report on the Panjáb Census of 1881, I have steadily kept two main objects before me. *Firstly*, I have attempted to produce a work which shall be useful to District officers as a handbook of reference on all the subjects dealt with in the Census Schedules, and which shall stand with regard to such subjects in a position somewhat similar to that occupied by the modern Settlement Report in respect of revenue matters. *Secondly*, I have endeavoured to record in some detail the experience gained at this Census, for guidance on the occasion of future enumerations. My pursuance of each of these objects has helped to swell the size of the report.

It would have been easy to write a short notice of some of the more obvious conclusions to be drawn from the Census totals of the Province as a whole; and such a notice would doubtless have technically sufficed as a report to Government upon the operations which I had superintended. But it would have been of small use for future reference, and would have served no purpose beyond that of furnishing the text for a Government resolution. A Census report is not meant merely for the information of the Secretariat; it is intended to be constantly referred to in every office of the Province. The mere results would ill serve this end in the absence of an interpreter. It is of but small advantage to cast voluminous tables of naked figures at the heads of District officers, without at the same time explaining what they represent, which can be done by no one but him who compiled them, and drawing from them the more important conclusions to which they lead, which few will draw but he whose special business it is to do so[1].

In the ordinary routine of district work, information is constantly needed regarding some feature or other of the society which we govern. That information often exists in print; but in India libraries are few and books scarce; while where the latter are available, they are often too detailed or too learned for the practical purposes of the District officer. It has been my endeavour to furnish such a sketch of the salient features of native society in the Panjáb as will often supply the immediate need, and at the same time to indicate where, if anywhere, further details may be found. A Census report is not light reading; and men take it up, not to read it through, but to obtain from it information on some definite point. It is therefore more important that it should be complete than that it should be brief; and so long as its arrangement directs the student at once to the place where he will find what he wants, without compelling him to wade through irrelevant matter, the fuller the information which he there finds on the subject, the more valuable will the report be to him. I have therefore omitted nothing relevant that seemed to me to be interesting or useful, simply because it occupied space.

The difficulty of an Indian Census springs mainly from two sources; the infinite diversity of the material to be dealt with, and our own infinite ignorance of that material. The present Census was, as regards the Panjáb and in respect of its minuteness and accuracy of detail, practically a first experiment; and one of its most valuable results has been to show us where our chief difficulties lie, and how and why we have on this occasion frequently failed to overcome them. If the present Census had been one for all time, nothing more would have been needed than such a brief account of the operations as would have explained to the student of the results how those results had been obtained. If, on the other hand, a Census were of annual recurrence, an "office," with its permanent staff and traditions, would have taken the place of the record of the experience which I have attempted too

[1] Much of the length of the report is due to the exceptionally large number of the administrative units for which the figures had to be discussed. (See section 929, page 468.) The Native States took great pains with the Census; and, apart from Temple intrinsic value of the results, it would have been ungracious to discuss their figures less fully than our own.

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